

disparity was remedied, but lasting damage had been done to Black morale.

Never redressed was the apparent unfairness of disallowing Black officers, with very rare exceptions. In all the Black regiments that served in the war, there were only 32 Black officers—and most were chaplains and surgeons. A school to train officer candidates for Black regiments opened in Philadelphia in late 1863, but its only graduates were white.

Routine work

Black regiments were often detailed to mundane second-line duties, such as digging trenches, clearing trees, guarding railroads, and protecting communication lines. Even after Black valor was proven by the assault on Port Hudson on May 27, 1863, where the bravery of Black regiments first came to the Northern public's attention, troops rarely saw action proportional to their numbers in the Union armies.

When Black units were called on to fight in a decisive action, such as at the Battle of the Crater, it was often under adverse conditions that made high casualty rates likely. This fact disgruntled many people in the ranks, leading to recruitment difficulties later. Even so, Black Americans made up 12 percent of Union soldiers by the end of the war.